the thing and be gone. Amazing, really, when you think about the impact he had not just on me and the rest of the players but on the whole club. We didn't talk to him but we talked about him almost all the time.

Eric could do no wrong in my eyes. And I think the manager was a bit in awe of him as well. One evening we were at a premiere of one of the *Batman* films. It was a club invitation so we were all supposed to turn up in black tie. Eric arrived wearing a white suit and his bright red Nike sneakers. I laugh about it now, after the ear bashings I used to get from the boss about the clothes I chose to wear. Eric was special, though. The manager knew that and so did all the players. We never begrudged him being treated differently to the rest of us.

Eric was a class apart. If anyone tried it on, he made sure you knew that. Not that people risked it very often. There was one evening, after a game, when we'd arranged a 'team meeting': it was just a night out with the lads but calling it that meant you knew everybody had to be there. We'd planned to meet at a place in Manchester called the Four Seasons at six forty-five and then go on from there. By seven, only Eric was missing. He eventually strolled up and Giggsy pointed to his watch:

'Seven o'clock, Eric.'

Ryan was doing his best to sound like the boss if you were late for training. Eric looked over:

'Six forty-five.'

Giggsy looked at his watch but, before he could say another word, Eric hitched up his sleeve and showed us the face of the most beautiful Rolex watch any of us had ever seen:

'Six forty-five,' he smiled.

End of argument. How could that watch, or the bloke wearing it, possibly be wrong about the time?

Watching Eric was a soccer education, especially in the way he used to practice. Every day, after training, he would be out there on a field at the Cliff, working on his own. He'd be taking free-kicks, doing his turns and little tricks, just as you might expect. But most of the time he'd be practicing the simplest things. He'd kick the ball up in the air as high as he could and then bring it under control as it dropped. He'd kick the ball against a wall, right